

has come to dictate the reflexes of the Indian establishment. In their case, it was not the fear of the unknown enemy but the fear of the very visible foe which compelled the political, business and entertainment classes to opt for wild, even illogical solutions for simple problems. If Farooq Abdullah decided to nominate his only son Omar as the next chief minister of Jammu and Kashmir without even waiting for the Congress to formally accept his offer, it had to do with his twin fears of losing his son's faith and archrival Mehbooba Mufti grabbing power once again. For both father and son, the fear of losing power for another six years has leapfrogged over any fear they may have had on supping with the same party that had backstabbed them in the past.

Fear is no more a temporary distraction and it has got everyone in its grip.

Down south, the AIADMK's Jayalalithaa—she of the 1,000 sandals and 10,000 saris—breaks bread with the Marxists who manage with just one pair of *hawai chappals*; and reaches out to the LTTE supporters like Vaiko because she fears that without the right mix and match, she may have to spend another five years without the elite security cover.

If Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi has kissed and made up with his grand-nephews, Kalanidhi

Maran and Dayanidhi Maran, it had a lot to do with fears of a palace coup and a few hundred crores of rupees from the successful family enterprises. Less than a year ago, Karunanidhi had forced Dayanidhi out from the Union Cabinet, where he was the communications minister; the DMK Government had launched a witchhunt against the Maran empire and Tamil Nadu's first family had even launched its own channel to counter Sun TV, owned by the Marans.

The brothers who were accused of sabotaging Karunanidhi's well laid-out succession plans that involved anointing his son M.K. Stalin as successor, are back in the household because the settlement is both political and financial. In Karnataka, B.S. Yeddyurappa, the BJP's unlikely icon in the south, has set new records in encouraging political defections. He was resourceful enough to force rebel MLAs from both the JD(U) and the Congress to resign and contest by-elections on his party's symbol because in that lay his dream of completing a full five-year term as chief minister.

It was a year in which our leaders were making landmark compromises. The fear of losing power just eight months before his current term was to end, compelled Prime Minister Manmohan Singh to personally work the phones to over 50 members of Lok Sabha whose names and faces he may have a hard time recollecting now. It was the same fear and objective that made Rahul Gandhi do the unthinkable and drive over to the residence of Amar Singh on a handful of occasions.

Amar Singh gives the impression that he doesn't know the meaning of the four-letter word fear. What then explains his change of heart over some issues that were never close to his party's socialist heart—the United States and particularly, the nuclear deal? All these years, the mere mention of Sonia Gandhi's name provoked his worst behaviour but a deal that took three days to seal now makes it look as if they have

HIGHS & LOWS

● India ended its nuclear apartheid after 34 years.

The 60 per cent voter turnout in the J&K elections was a sharp rebuff to the separatists' agenda.

The political consensus post-26/11 led to a strong anti-terror law and setting up of the NIA.

Voters opted for good governance in the recent assembly polls

The effete Shivraj Patil was finally replaced by P. Chidambaram.

● The Lok Sabha met for 46 days, the least in a calendar year.

First time ever, slush money was brandished in the Lok Sabha.

Attacks on Christians in Orissa after the killing of a Hindu saint.

Raj Thackeray's violent campaign against north Indians in Mumbai.

V.S. Achuthanandan's slur against a martyr's family unleashed a wave of disgust.

